



Female Entrepreneurs: gender diversity across the UK's high-growth ecosystem

We've highlighted key trends amongst, and disparities between, all-female, mixed-gender and all-male founding teams; from the funding they've received to the key support systems they've leveraged.

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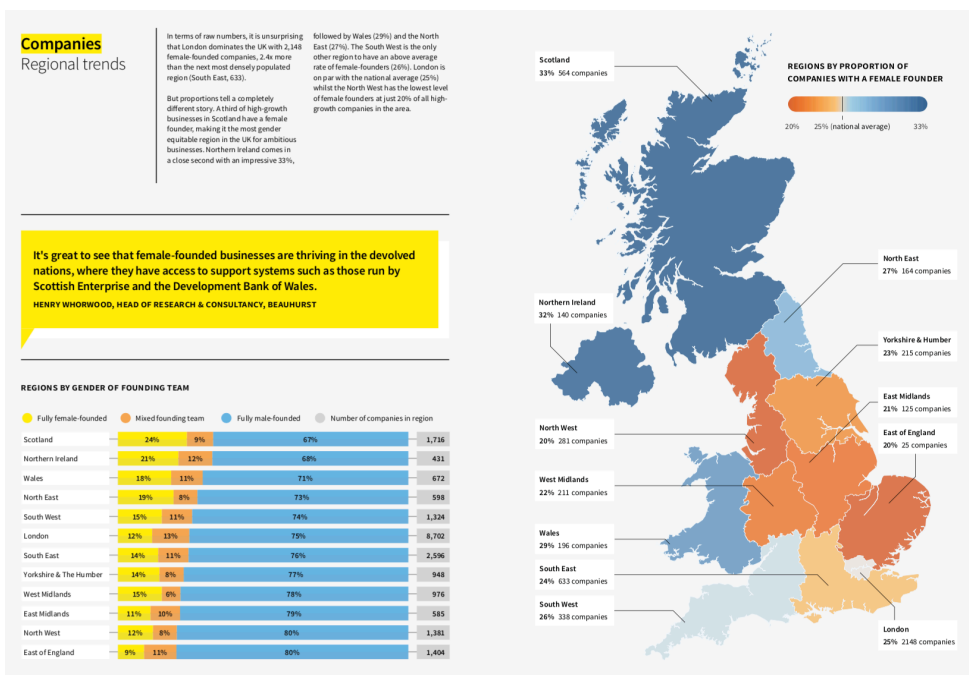
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What's inside?



Companies
25% of the UK's high-growth companies have a female founder, but which regions have a particularly high proportion and which may need more support?

Equity investment
The proportion of equity deals secured by teams with a female founder has increased from 14% in 2011 to a high of 22% in 2017. This figure has plateaued since.

Grant funding
Since 2012 the share of large innovation grants awarded to female founders has quadrupled to 16% – still a very low proportion.

accelerators
Fully-female-founded companies are most likely to have grown through an accelerators, more commonly opting for structure programmes instead of funding transactions.

Equity

Number of deals

Over the past eight years, the number of deals secured by companies with a female founder has grown massively, increasing 777% between 2011 and 2017. This is a much more accelerated rate of growth than the number of deals secured by companies with all-male founders, which only increased by 462% in the same period.

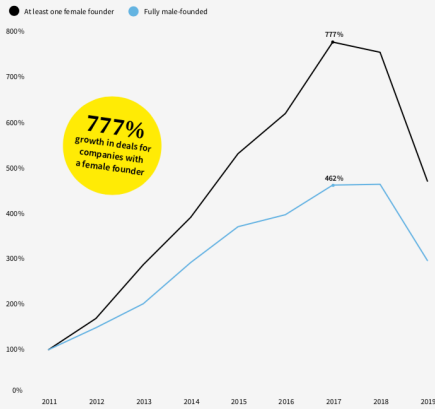
When we contextualise these figures within the overall proportion of deals going to teams with at least one female founder, the results are quite positive; this figure stood at just 14% in 2011, and reached a high of 22% in 2017 – significantly closer to the 25% of high-growth companies with a female founder. In 2019 so far, this figure stands at 21%.

We've seen a dramatic change in the proportion of first time rounds completed by female-founded teams, from 16% in 2011 to a high of 25% in 2017, and a slight dip to 23% in 2019 so far. Despite this plateau in the last two years, it's encouraging to see that figures were proportionate to the overall population of female-founded companies in the high-growth ecosystem in 2017.

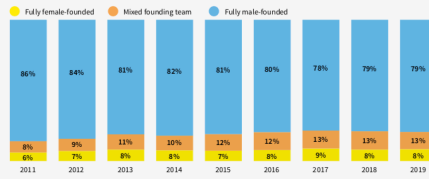
Questions about family, children, as well as general ability means that women have to spend a lot more energy proving themselves, and convincing the table they've established a viable market opportunity.

LU LI, CEO AND FOUNDER, BLOOMING FOUNDERS

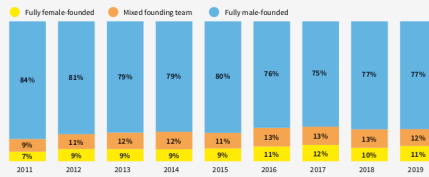
GROWTH IN DEAL NUMBERS



PROPORTION OF DEAL NUMBERS BY GENDER OF FOUNDING TEAM



PROPORTION OF FIRST TIME FUNDRAISINGS BY GENDER OF FOUNDING TEAM



Grants

Overview

The distribution of grant funding in the UK is one of the most alarming examples of gender disparity within the ecosystem. There has been no progression in the proportion of large innovation grants (>£100k) awarded to all-female founding

teams. Firstly, there are fewer female-founded companies in the sectors that are most frequently awarded grants than there are across the high-growth population as a whole. 69% of large innovation grants are deployed to companies in the technology

and 17% of female-founded businesses, respectively. But even taking these sector weightings into account, the proportion of grants going to female-founded companies is still lower than what we might expect.

with Getty Images to deliver a series of portraits shattering gender stereotypes, and installing commemorative plaques across the country to recognise female innovators. These are certainly a longer-term play, encouraging younger

able to scale their businesses. 9 winners have each received £50k and a bespoke package of support. Although this isn't classed as a 'large innovation grant', these are still an important part of the ecosystem, helping to build awareness

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2011 2012 2013 2014 2015 2016 2017 2018 2019

Accelerators

Overview

Accelerators are the most popular method of growth for female-founded businesses, and the only method to have an over-representation of women entrepreneurs. Despite making up 25% of the high-growth business population, female-founded companies make up 38% of the UK's population of accelerated businesses.

Accelerated companies have a fairly high death rate amongst all female and all-male teams (20% for both), but this

is a little lower for mixed-gender teams (16%). All male founding teams are the most likely to have progressed to a later stage of evolution following an accelerator attendance.

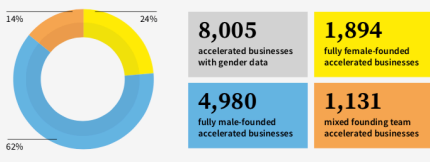
Of our cohort of companies accelerated between 2014 and 2015, 17% of all-male teams are now at Venture stage and 3% at Growth stage, and 44% remain at the seed stage. In comparison, 53% of mixed gender and 64% of all-female teams remain in the seed stage.

We currently track two accelerators that provide specialist support for female founders, Hatch's Female Founders and We in Social Tech. Run by Hatch Enterprise, Female Founders is a 4-month programme 'to help female-led businesses scale their venture, achieve a better market fit and reach their professional goals.'

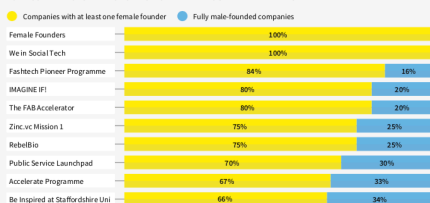
Some accelerators may invest money, but they will also help develop entrepreneurs' skills and grow the business, and I think female founders in particular are drawn to that extra value.

KATIE NAGY DE NAGYBACZON, PARTNER, CMS

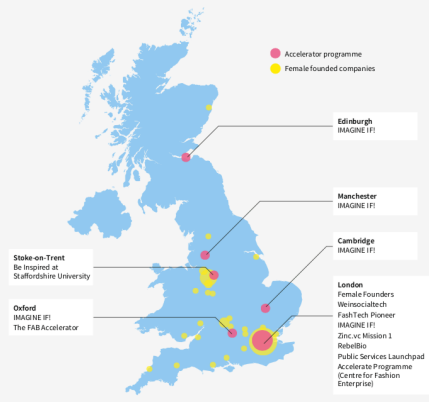
ACCELERATED COMPANIES BY GENDER OF FOUNDING TEAM



TOP ACCELERATORS BY PROPORTION OF FEMALE-FOUNDED ATTENDEES



LOCATION OF TOP ACCELERATORS AND FEMALE-FOUNDED ACCELERATEES



About the authors



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Hannah leads on Beauhurst's data-driven publications and content creation, and is an expert on emerging trends in the UK's high-growth space. Hannah studied Liberal Arts with a major in English Literature at King's College London.



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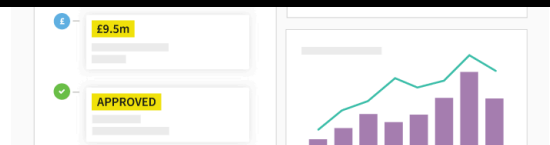
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